Soviet Union exceeding that posed by Soviet missiles against the United States. And, he asked:

> How can the Soviet Union view the Pershing II missiles deployed in Europe with their high accuracy and short flight time to USSR targets as anything else but first strike weapons? Please forgive me for being concerned with technical details in a personal letter of this kind, but, really, this is a vitally important situation and it simply cannot be avoided. Believe me, Mr. President, we have a real and extremely serious concern over U.S. nuclear weapons. You speak of mutual concerns. The solution of this problem is only possible through consideration and calculations of the sum total of the corresponding weapons on both sides.

Then Gorbachev gave his reaction to what I'd said about "regional conflicts," a euphemism to describe Soviet adventurism in Third World countries.

Let's, he said,

> see the world as it is. Both of us offer such assistance. Why apply a double standard here that Soviet aid is a source of tension and American assistance is good will? Better to be guided by objective criteria. The Soviet Union will help lawful governments which ask us for aid because they have been and are being subjected to external armed interference. But the U.S., and such are the facts, inspires action against governments and arms anti-social, and in essence, terrorist groups. Looking at the matter objectively, it is specifically such external interference which creates regional tension and conflict situations. Were there no such activities, I am sure tensions would be reduced and the prospects for political settlements will become much better and more realistic.